

THE PARENT-COACH PLAYBOOK

What to Say When.

A field guide for sports parents.

Twenty-three scripts for the moments before and after the game, and the hard ones in between. By age. Calibrated for the car, the kitchen, the parking lot.

EDITED BY THE PCP DESK

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01 / HOW TO USE THIS

Twenty-three scripts. One pattern.

Pick the one you need. Read it once, then put it down.

This guide is built around one observation: the most important sentences a parent says about their kid's sport happen in two narrow windows. The minute before the game. The first ninety seconds after. Most parents wing it. Most parents wish they hadn't.

Every script in here gives you the same five things: what your kid is probably feeling, three things you can say, three you shouldn't, the rule underneath, and what to do if they bring it up. Read the one that fits the moment. Don't memorize the whole book.

THREE THINGS THAT WILL MAKE THIS WORK

- Read the script the morning of, not in the parking lot. The car is for being present, not consulting a manual.
- Use the words. The first three or four times, say them the way they're written. After that, the muscle memory is yours.
- Trust the silences. Most of these scripts work because of what's not in them.

"Specificity beats praise. Presence beats evaluation. The car ride is not the classroom."

02 / THE FRAMEWORK

What every script does, in three sentences.

The pattern under the lines.

Every script in this guide does three things in three sentences or fewer. The pattern is older than youth sports. It's the same pattern a good coach uses on the bench and a good boss uses after a missed deadline.

01 · NAME A MOMENT THEY HAD AGENCY IN

Not the score. Not the result. A specific thing they did or chose. "Glad you got to bat in the fourth." "I liked your stick position on ground balls." The detail signals: I was watching the parts you can control.

02 · SKIP EVALUATION

No grades. No comparison. No "you should have." The kid already evaluated the game on the field. Repeating it adds nothing the kid couldn't supply themselves and sets the temperature for the next seven days.

03 · HAND THEM SOMETHING NEXT

Pizza. Homework. The dog. Whatever is next that has nothing to do with the sport. The kid needs an off-ramp from the role they were just playing.

THREE THINGS NEVER TO LEAD WITH

Don't ask the score first. They lived it. If you ask, you signal that the score was the point. It wasn't.

Don't question the coach. You weren't on the bench. They were. The question forces them to defend a person they need to keep trusting.

Don't compare. Not to a sibling. Not to a teammate. Not to yourself at that age. None of those three are in the car.

BEFORE A GAME / AGE 5-7

The no-stakes script.

Kids this age don't need a pep talk. They need to know the snack situation.

FEELING

Excited about the uniform.
 Hungry.
 Curious about which friend is on the team today.
 Not really thinking about the game yet.

SAY

"I'm going to be on the bleachers cheering."
"What snack do you want after?"
"Have fun out there."

DON'T

"Today's the day."
"Remember what we worked on."
"If you score, I'll get you ice cream."

THE RULE

Kids this age aren't having performance anxiety. Don't install it for them by treating the game like it matters.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- If they ask if you'll be watching, the answer is yes. Don't add anything else.
- If they say they're nervous, ask what about. Then say "okay, we'll see what happens."
- If they ask whether they'll win, the answer is "I don't know, neither does anyone."

BEFORE A GAME / AGE 8–10

The effort-not-outcome script.

They're starting to care about winning. Don't build the conditional love around it.

FEELING

Aware that some kids are better than others.

Watching to see who their friends are passing to.

Wanting to do well in front of you.

Not yet sure what to do with nerves.

SAY

"I love watching you play."

"Try one thing you've been working on."

"Have fun out there."

DON'T

"Just don't strike out."

"Coach said you'd start. Make sure he keeps you in."

"We need a win today."

THE RULE

Reinforce the part they can control. Effort. Attempt. Whatever they've been working on. Skip outcomes.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- If they ask whether they'll start, say what you know. "I think so" is honest. "I don't know" is too. "Definitely" is not yours to give.
- If they say they're nervous, ask what they're nervous about. Listen first. Don't fix it.
- If they want a pep talk, give them a real one in five words. "You've worked. Go play. Have fun."

BEFORE A GAME / AGE 11–12

When real nerves arrive.*Name the feeling without inflating it. Three sentences, not a speech.***FEELING**

Real pre-game nerves for the first time.
 Aware of who is watching.
 Comparing themselves to the kid who is better.
 Tracking playing time and roster decisions in their head.
 Wondering if you'll be disappointed if they don't perform.

SAY

“Your job today is the same as practice. Play hard. Stay coachable.”
“You don't have to play your best for me to be proud of you.”
“I'll see you after.”

DON'T

“If you have a good game, we'll go to...”
“Coach told me you need to...”
“Don't be nervous.”

THE RULE*Decouple your approval from their performance. Say it out loud, once, before they walk to the dugout.***IF THEY BRING IT UP**

- If they say they're nervous, name it back. “Yeah, the body does that. Means you care.” Then change the subject.
- If they ask whether you think they'll do well, the answer is “I think you'll play hard. I trust the rest.”
- If they ask about playing time or starting, be honest. They are old enough to handle “I don't know.”

BEFORE A GAME / AGE 13–14

The silence move.

They don't want a speech. Most don't want any words at all. Here's what they actually need.

FEELING

Self-conscious about being seen with you.
 Already in their own head about the game.
 Worried about something specific they don't want to talk about.
 Wanting you to be there. Wanting you to not say much.
 Carrying middle-school weight that has nothing to do with the game.

SAY

"I'll be there."
"Music?"
"Text me if you need anything."

DON'T

"What position are you playing today?"
"Did you eat enough?"
"Coach is going to give you minutes if you..."

THE RULE

At this age, the most loving thing you can offer before a game is presence without performance. Drive them there. Put on their music. Be quiet.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- If they bring up the game, follow their lead. Don't add. Don't escalate. Match the temperature exactly.
- If they want to talk about something else, talk about that. School. A friend. The song. Whatever they pick.
- If they're frustrated about something on the team, listen. Don't fix it before the game. Just hold it.

BEFORE A GAME / WHEN THEY'RE NERVOUS

Nerves mean it matters.

Stomach in knots. Saying they don't want to go. The script that calms without dismissing.

FEELING

Pre-game stomach.
 Imagining everything that could go wrong.
 Wishing they could skip it.
 Sometimes wanting you to make it go away.

SAY

“Nerves mean it matters. That's allowed.”
“Want to walk me through your first play?”
“Whatever happens out there, we go get food after.”

DON'T

“You'll be fine, don't worry about it.”
“Just go out and have fun.”
“Other kids don't get nervous like this.”

THE RULE

Don't promise the outcome. Promise the relationship.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- Listen to the specific worry. Don't generalize it.
- Help them name what they can control: warm-up routine, breathing, the first play.
- Skip the pep talk. They don't want one.

BEFORE A GAME / THE CHAMPIONSHIP

Lower the temperature.

The big game looms. They can't sleep. Your job is not a pep talk.

FEELING

Pressure they haven't carried before.
 Aware that everyone is watching.
 Re-running the season's biggest moments in their head.
 Worried they'll let the team down.
 Sometimes excited and don't know how to hold it.

SAY

*"It's just another game. Same field.
 Same teammates. Same warm-up."
 "I'm proud of how you got here. The
 season is already a thing you did."
 "Whatever happens tomorrow, we go
 get food after."*

DON'T

*"This is the biggest day of your life."
 "Don't let me down."
 "Win this for grandma."*

THE RULE

Lower the temperature, don't raise it. The game is loud enough on its own.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- If they want to talk strategy, listen, don't add your own.
- If they say they're scared, validate. "Yeah, this one is bigger. The body knows."
- If they can't sleep, don't make them. Sit with them. Read together. Don't lecture about sleep.

BEFORE A GAME / SUMMER TRYOUTS

An audition for one day.

The tryout that doesn't have a season behind it. Higher stakes, less context.

FEELING

Stomach-in-knots nervous, often more than season tryouts.

Aware that summer tryouts feel like an audition with no warm-up.

Worried about who else is trying out.

SAY

“Just play your game today.”

“Whatever happens, we go get food after.”

“Tell me one thing you're going to focus on.”

DON'T

“You have to make it.”

“Don't blow this.”

“Coach said he was looking for you.”

THE RULE

Tryouts are an audition for one day. Not a verdict on the kid.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- If they want to walk through their plan, listen. Don't add.
- If they go silent, let them. Quiet is part of pre-game.
- If they cry, sit in it. The car can wait one more minute.

AFTER A GAME / AGE 5-7

Just feed them.

The post-game window at this age is short, simple, and mostly about juice boxes.

FEELING

Hungry.
Hot or cold.
Looking around for the friend who they want to play with after.
Vaguely aware of whether they had fun.
Not at all aware of the score.

SAY

"I had fun watching you out there."
"What sounded better, pizza or McDonald's?"
"Nice job, buddy."

DON'T

"What happened in the second inning?"
"Why didn't you go for that ball?"
"Their team had a kid that was huge."

THE RULE

Don't review tape with a six-year-old. They were running around with their friends. Match that energy.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- If they say they had fun, the response is "me too."
- If they say they didn't have fun, ask what about. Listen. Don't fix it.
- If they bring up the score, the answer is "yeah, sometimes that's how it goes." Don't dwell.

AFTER A GAME / AGE 8-10

The 90-second rule.

The post-game window here decides what the rest of the week feels like.

FEELING

Aware of the score.
 Replaying their best play and their worst play.
 Watching to see how you're going to react.
 Hungry. Tired. Maybe holding tears.
 Wondering whether their effort showed.

SAY

"I'm glad I got to watch you play."
"What did you like about it?"
"Want to grab something to eat?"

DON'T

"Why didn't you..."
"You should have..."
"If you'd just listened in practice last week..."

THE RULE

The first 90 seconds are not for review. They are for rejoining. Lead with warmth. Save the tape for later. Mostly, never.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- If they bring up a mistake, listen first. Reflect what they said before adding anything.
- If they bring up a teammate's mistake, the answer is "that's tough." Don't pile on.
- If they bring up the coach, listen. "What did he say to you about it?" is enough.

AFTER A GAME / AGE 11–12

One question, then drive.

A different cadence than the younger ages. Less talking. More space.

FEELING

Self-aware about how they played.
 Tracking the social temperature in the dugout.
 Comparing themselves to the kids who got more minutes.
 Filtering what they tell you so you don't make a thing of it.
 Hungry. Tired. Maybe a little fragile.

SAY

“Good to see you out there.”
“Tell me when you want food.”
“(Then wait. Just drive.)”

DON'T

“How did it go?”
“I noticed in the third quarter you...”
“Anything that starts with ‘next time.’”

THE RULE

At this age, you ask one question and then you stop. The next thing they say is the real conversation. Don't jump in to fill silence.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- If they bring up a teammate, listen. Most of what's processing at 11–12 is social, not technical.
- If they bring up playing time, ask what their read was. Their read might be more accurate than yours.
- If they bring up the coach, listen carefully. The coach trust window is real.

AFTER A GAME / AGE 13–14

Be the safest car.*When they don't want to talk. Music, snacks, no interview questions.***FEELING**

Tired of being asked how they did.
 Embarrassed if it went badly. Embarrassed if it went well.
 Sorting through middle-school dynamics that have nothing to do with the game.
 Aware that the family wants to feel something with them, and not sure how much they want to give.
 Watching their phone for the post-game group chat.

SAY

“(Nothing for the first ten minutes.)”
“Eventually: ‘You hungry?’”
“If they want to talk: ‘I’m here.’”

DON'T

“How did it go?”
“What happened on that play?”
“I saw the coach pull you. Did he say why?”

THE RULE*Be the safest car they get into. The safest car has music, has snacks, has a parent who is not running interview questions.***IF THEY BRING IT UP**

- If they bring up the game, follow their lead. Match their energy. Don't escalate.
- If they say it was bad, the right move is “yeah, that looked tough.” Then quiet.
- If they say it was good, “I had fun watching you” is better than “congratulations.”

AFTER A WIN

Don't move the goalpost.*Wins matter too. Let them enjoy it before you start coaching.***FEELING**

Proud.

Sometimes relieved.

Watching to see if you'll be excited with them, or if you'll start coaching.

SAY*"That was fun to watch."**"I loved your energy today."**"Tell me about the play you liked best."***DON'T***"Now next week we have to..."**"Imagine if you'd done that all year..."**"You almost had another one."***THE RULE***Let them enjoy it before you move the goalpost.***IF THEY BRING IT UP**

- If they want to break down the game with you, do it. Their lead, their pace.
- Skip the next-game framing. Tonight is for tonight.
- Don't compare to the kid who scored more.

AFTER A LOSS

A loss deserves to be a loss.

The team played hard and still came up short. Don't talk them out of feeling it.

FEELING

Disappointment that goes deeper than a regular bad day.

Sometimes guilt about a specific moment, even if they weren't the only one in it.

Questioning whether the work was worth it.

Tired in a way that's not just physical.

SAY

"That hurts. I'm sorry."

"I loved the way you played."

"Want quiet, or want to talk?"

DON'T

"It's just a game."

"You'll get them next time."

"If you'd just done X, you would have won."

THE RULE

A loss deserves to be a loss. Don't talk them out of feeling it.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- Sit with the feeling. Don't fix it.
- If they want to talk through what happened, listen first. Don't add.
- Save "what we learned" for next week. Tonight is for tonight.

AFTER A BAD GAME

They already know.*The script that protects the relationship and the rest of the week.***FEELING**

Embarrassed.
 Replaying mistakes in their head.
 Wondering how you're going to react.
 Tired and exposed.

SAY

"I'm glad I got to watch you play."
"That looked like a tough one."
"Want to grab something to eat?"

DON'T

"Why didn't you..."
"You should have..."
"Coach should have..."

THE RULE*They already know what went wrong. They don't need you to confirm it.***IF THEY BRING IT UP**

- Listen first. Don't jump to solutions.
- Reflect what they said before adding anything.
- Ask one question. Maximum. Then let them lead.

AFTER A MISTAKE

Mistakes are not identities.*The dropped ball, the missed shot, the play that cost the game.***FEELING**

Exposed.
 Worried they let teammates down.
 Replaying the moment on a loop.
 Bracing for criticism from you.

SAY

“That happens to everyone who plays.”
“I’m proud of you for staying in it.”
“Want to talk about it now or later?”

DON'T

“If you’d just...”
“We’ve worked on that a hundred times.”
“You cost the game.”

THE RULE

Mistakes are part of playing. Shame is not part of growing.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- Don't replay the mistake with them. They've already done it ten times.
- If they want to talk technique, do it Tuesday with a coach, not in the car.
- Name something they did right in the same game. Specific.

AFTER NO PLAYING TIME

Don't make the coach the enemy.

The hardest car ride of the season. Help your kid stay in control of what they can improve.

FEELING

Overlooked.
Frustrated, sometimes ashamed.
Wondering if they're not good enough.
Watching whether you're going to make it about the coach.

SAY

"I know that was hard."
"I'm proud of how you stayed ready."
"Do you want to vent, or do you want help thinking through it?"

DON'T

"That coach is terrible."
"You're better than half those kids."
"I'm going to talk to him."

THE RULE

Don't make the coach the enemy. Help your kid stay in control of what they can improve.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- Let them vent first. Don't jump to fixing.
- If they want help, focus on what's in their control: effort, attitude, asking the coach a real question.
- Save the coach conversation for a Tuesday, not the car ride.

WHEN THEY'RE SILENT

Silence is allowed.*Headphones on. Window seat. Nothing to say. Silence is not a problem to fix.***FEELING**

Processing.
 Tired.
 Not ready to perform conversation for you.
 Sometimes nothing — and that's allowed.

SAY

“Glad you're here.”
“Want music, quiet, or talk?”
“I'll just drive.”

DON'T

“Why are you so quiet?”
“Are you mad at me?”
“Is something wrong?”

THE RULE*Silence is not a problem. It's a season of the conversation.***IF THEY BRING IT UP**

- If they start, the rule from After a bad game applies. Listen, reflect, one question max.
- If they don't start, that's also fine. The car can be a quiet place.
- Same drive again next week. Don't make this one carry too much.

WHEN THEY'RE UPSET

Regulate before you evaluate.

Tears in the parking lot. Slamming the car door. The script for moments words don't reach yet.

FEELING

Overwhelmed.
Embarrassed about being overwhelmed.
Not ready to be fixed.
Watching you to see if you can handle it.

SAY

"I'm here."
"That looked like a lot."
"Take whatever time you need."

DON'T

"It's not that big a deal."
"Don't cry, you're fine."
"Tell me what happened, right now."

THE RULE

Regulate the moment before you evaluate it.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- Sit in the silence. It's not your job to fill it.
- If they cry, let them cry. Don't talk over it.
- When they're ready, they'll start. Match their pace, not yours.

AFTER A TEAMMATE'S INJURY

Slow down. Don't rush past it.*The kid who saw it happen. The kid who was on the play.***FEELING**

Shaken. Sometimes more than they show.

Worried about the teammate.

If they were on the play, guilty even if they didn't cause it.

Worried it could happen to them.

Not sure whether it's okay to think about anything else.

SAY

"That was scary. I'm glad you're okay."

"Do you know if they're going to be alright?"

"Is there anything you want to do tonight, like text them?"

DON'T

"These things happen, don't worry about it."

"You're fine. They'll be fine."

"That's why I told you to keep your head up."

THE RULE*Witnessing an injury is its own thing. Don't rush past it. Don't make them perform okay-ness.***IF THEY BRING IT UP**

- Let them tell what they saw at their pace.
- If they were involved in the play, name it: "That was an accident. Accidents happen in sports."
- Encourage but don't force them to reach out to the teammate.
- Watch their sleep and mood for the next week. Witnessing real injury sometimes shows up later.

POST-CUT / THE FIRST NIGHT

Today doesn't change us.*The kid got cut. The next twelve hours are about the kid, not the verdict.***FEELING**

Devastated, embarrassed, both.

Watching their phone for the group chat reaction.

Wondering whether their friends still want them around.

Bracing for what their parents are going to say.

SAY

"I love you. Today doesn't change that."

"Want food, want quiet, want a movie night?"

"We can talk about it tomorrow if you want, or never. Up to you."

DON'T

"It's their loss."

"We'll get them next year."

"I bet the kids who made it weren't even better than you."

THE RULE*The cut is the cut. The next twelve hours are about the kid, not the verdict.***IF THEY BRING IT UP**

- Listen. Don't strategize. Strategy is for next week.
- If they ask why, the honest answer is "I don't know all the reasons. Coaches see things you and I can't see in tryouts."
- Don't trash the coach. Don't trash the kids who made it. Stay above it.

WHEN THEY DON'T MAKE CAPTAIN

Find out how they feel.*The kid who thought they would. Sometimes they say something. Often they don't.***FEELING**

Surprised, even if they pretend not to be.
 Re-evaluating how they're seen by the team.
 Sometimes embarrassed they hoped for it.
 Watching whether you'll bring it up.

SAY

"I saw the captain announcement."
"How are you feeling about it?"
"(Then quiet. Wait.)"

DON'T

"You should have been captain."
"Coach made a mistake."
"It's not a big deal."

THE RULE*Don't tell them how to feel about it. Find out how they feel about it.***IF THEY BRING IT UP**

- If they say they don't care, ask one follow-up. "Are you sure?" Listen to the answer.
- If they say they're upset, validate without getting bigger. "Yeah, you put in the work to be considered. That's real."
- If they ask why, the honest answer is "Captain decisions are about a lot of things. The coach saw something this year."
- Don't volunteer that you'll talk to the coach. You won't, and offering it sets up a different problem.

AFTER A MELTDOWN AT PRACTICE

Regulate first. Lecture never.

Tears, walking off, throwing equipment. The script for picking them up afterward.

FEELING

Mortified.

Sometimes still in the moment, sometimes already shut down.

Watching to see if you're going to bring it up at home.

Sometimes physically hungry or tired in a way that built into a meltdown.

SAY

"I'm here. Take whatever time."

"When you're ready to eat, let me know."

"We don't have to talk about practice tonight unless you want to."

DON'T

"What is wrong with you?"

"You can't do that in front of the team."

"We're going to have a talk when we get home."

THE RULE

Regulate first. Evaluate later. Sometimes evaluation is the next day. Sometimes it's never.

IF THEY BRING IT UP

- If they explain, listen. Don't fix the explanation.
- If they apologize, accept. "I love you. Tough practice." Move on.
- If a pattern emerges, the conversation about why practice keeps melting them down is its own conversation. Pick a calm moment.

AFTER THE LAST GAME

Tonight is for tonight.*Win or lose, the kid is processing more than the score.***FEELING**

All of it at once.
 Sad it's over, even if they wanted it to end.
 Relieved, even if they loved it.
 Wondering what next year looks like.

SAY

"I loved watching you play this year."
"Thanks for letting me come watch."
"What was your favorite thing about this team?"

DON'T

"Now we need to talk about next year."
"I think you should try out for the higher team."
"There's always next year."

THE RULE*Tonight is for the season that just ended. Next year is for next month.***IF THEY BRING IT UP**

- If they bring up next year, listen, don't decide.
- If they cry, let them cry. The end of seasons hits hard.
- If they say "I'm glad it's over," believe them.

THE POCKET CARD

Cut, fold, glove box.

Cut along the outer edge of the panel below. Fold along the two vertical lines so it accordions into a glove-box-sized card. Read the relevant panel before the game, after the game, and on the hard nights. After a month, you won't need it.

BEFORE Before the game • Three sentences, max. • Reinforce something they can control. • Don't promise the outcome. Promise the relationship. • Then drop them and go. <i>Never:</i> build conditional love around starting / scoring / winning.	AFTER First 90 seconds • Lead with one specific moment they had agency in. • Skip the score. Skip the breakdown. • Stop talking. Quiet for a full mile. • Hand them what's next. Pizza. Homework. The dog. <i>Never:</i> ask the score, question the coach, or compare to anyone.	HARD MOMENTS When it's heavy • Regulate before you evaluate. • Sit in the silence. Don't fill it. • Match their pace, not yours. • Tomorrow is for tomorrow. <i>Never:</i> fix what you haven't yet listened to.
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KEEP READING

The work doesn't end at the curb.

If this guide helped, the publication has more. The Parent-Coach Playbook is sideline notes for parents who coach, drive, snack-pack, and supervise the group chat.

WHAT'S IN THE ARCHIVE

Scripts for the conversations this guide doesn't cover — the coach you can't read, the parent ruining the team chat, the 7am text from the head coach, the kid who wants to quit. Reads on tryouts, travel teams, and the honest math of rec versus club. Buying guides by sport. A cost calculator that tells you the real annual price of any sport before you sign up.

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